

A Product Thought: Personalized Creator Subscriptions on YouTube

— A Product & Platform Thinking Exploration

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Note

This report was explored and refined through AI-assisted discussions. The core idea flow, natural prompts, and questioning style included toward the end reflect my original thought process.

Why This Thought Came to My Mind

Lately, I've been spending a lot of time on YouTube. Mostly long-form content — TEDx talks, podcasts, creator interviews, and lately videos around intelligence psychology and behavioral analysis from Andrew Bustamante. Funny enough, I discovered him through a random Diary of a CEO clip.

While watching, one thought kept repeating in my head:

“I genuinely enjoy content from specific creators. But I still wouldn't buy full YouTube Premium.”

And then another question crossed my mind:

“What if users could subscribe only to the creators they actually care about?”

Not as memberships inside individual channels, but as a platform-level personalized subscription system.

That was the starting point of this thought experiment.

Current Observation

Most people around me don't necessarily hate YouTube ads.

They hate interruption.

Especially:

- during podcasts,
- educational videos,
- storytelling,
- music,
- long-form discussions.

At the same time, I noticed something interesting: people are emotionally attached to creators more than platforms.

Someone may not pay ₹149 for YouTube Premium, but they may happily pay ₹29–₹79 for:

- their favorite educator,
- podcast creator,
- fitness creator,
- finance channel,
- or even music creator.

That difference in psychology interested me.

Initial Product Thought

The idea started as:

“What if YouTube allowed creator-based subscriptions?”

Example:

- Subscribe to 1 creator
- Subscribe to 3 creators
- Subscribe to 7 creators
- Or simply buy full YouTube Premium

The important part was: users should feel like they are building “their own YouTube.”

Not paying for features they don’t use.

Why It Felt Interesting

I started thinking from both:

- user side,

- and business side.

User Side

Lower pricing may attract first-time paying users.

Especially in countries like India where: people are willing to spend, but only when value feels personal.

A user may hesitate before buying YouTube Premium, but may happily pay for:

- a podcast creator they listen to daily,
- a fitness creator they trust,
- or an educator whose content genuinely helps them.

This lowers psychological entry barriers.

Creator Side

Creators become less dependent only on:

- ads,
- sponsors,
- external courses,
- or brand deals.

This could especially help:

- educational creators,
- niche creators,
- long-form creators,
- and creators building loyal communities.

Many creators already teach complete concepts on YouTube itself. This model may allow users to support them directly without necessarily moving to external paid ecosystems.

Then Bigger Questions Started Coming

The more I thought about it, the more complicated it became.

One question was:

“Would this slowly kill YouTube Premium itself?”

Then another:

“Would people get tired managing too many subscriptions?”

And another:

“Would big creators become too expensive while small creators disappear?”

That’s when the thought process became less about “feature idea” and more about platform behavior.

Possible Pricing Structure

Instead of individual pricing chaos, I thought maybe bundles could simplify the experience:

- 1 Creator Pass
- 3 Creator Bundle
- 7 Creator Bundle
- Full Premium

This creates upgrade paths naturally.

A casual user may buy 1 creator. A regular viewer may buy 3. A heavy user may directly shift to Premium.

This also protects YouTube Premium instead of directly competing with it.

The system slowly becomes:

- entry-level personalization,
 - followed by larger ecosystem adoption.
-

Why Bundles Felt Operationally Better

Fully dynamic creator pricing initially sounded logical.

But later I realized it could create problems.

Problem 1 — Big Creators Become Too Expensive

If:

- large creators,
- podcasters,
- or elite educators

become significantly costlier, users may feel punished for liking successful creators.

That may create backlash.

Problem 2 — Engagement Manipulation

If subscription pricing depends heavily on:

- likes,
- comments,
- ENGAGEMENT,
- or CTR,

creators may aggressively optimize for:

- outrage,
- controversy,
- emotional dependency,
- ragebait,
- or manipulative engagement.

That may distort content quality.

Problem 3 — Complexity Kills Adoption

Consumers usually prefer:

- simple,
- predictable,
- emotionally easy systems.

If users start seeing:

“This creator costs +₹20 due to engagement score...”

the platform may become mentally exhausting.

That’s why bundles felt cleaner than visible dynamic pricing.

Self-Regulating Ecosystem Thought

One thought that interested me was whether the ecosystem could partially regulate itself.

Example:

- creators who aggressively optimize engagement may become expensive,
- users may return to free YouTube,
- or shift toward better-value creators,
- while heavy users may directly upgrade to Premium.

This creates a balancing cycle between:

- creators,
- users,
- subscriptions,
- and platform value.

I also thought CREDIT POINTS and subscription flexibility could help.

For example:

- creator swaps,
- rotating creator slots,
- loyalty points,
- or subscription credits

may reduce subscription fatigue while keeping users inside the ecosystem.

The Part That Interested Me Most

I realized YouTube currently monetizes ATTENTION.

This model may monetize LOYALTY.

That changes creator incentives.

Ads reward:

- clicks,
- virality,
- retention hacks.

Subscriptions reward:

- trust,
- consistency,

- long-form value,
- and creator relationships.

That shift felt strategically important.

Long-Form Content Advantage

This model may also strengthen YouTube's biggest advantage over short-form platforms: DEPTH.

Platforms driven mainly by short-form algorithms optimize:

- fast dopamine,
- short retention bursts,
- endless scrolling behavior.

But creator-based subscriptions may strengthen:

- long-form engagement,
- podcasts,
- educational content,
- creator trust,
- and user loyalty.

This may help YouTube compete differently instead of trying to purely imitate short-form ecosystems.

Observation About Ads

Initially, I thought subscriptions may reduce ad revenue.

But later I realized: ads may not disappear.

They may simply become less interruptive.

Instead of:

- pre-roll ads,
- mid-roll interruptions,
- forced waiting,

advertising may shift toward:

- homepage visuals,
- recommendation ads,
- creator sponsorship placements,

- ecosystem-level personalized ads.

That may preserve monetization while improving experience.

This may also increase ad quality because subscription behavior itself becomes a strong signal of user interest.

But There Were Risks Too

One concern I had was:

“Will creators start manipulating engagement metrics to become premium-tier creators?”

Another concern:

“Will users become trapped inside creator bubbles?”

And another:

“Could platforms become too personalized over time?”

If users only subscribe to creators they already agree with, it may slowly reduce:

- exploration,
- intellectual diversity,
- and curiosity.

At the same time, creator ecosystems may become stronger identity systems.

That helps retention, but may create social and psychological concerns as well.

The Biggest Concern: NAVIGATION

Honestly, the biggest fear I had was not revenue.

It was NAVIGATION.

YouTube already contains:

- Shorts,
- Podcasts,
- Community,

- Memberships,
- Shopping,
- Premium,
- Live streams,
- YouTube Music,
- Courses,
- Recommendations.

Adding more monetization layers could easily overwhelm users.

That's when one important thought came to my mind:

“Complex backend systems should still feel emotionally simple.”

Users should not feel:

“I'm managing subscriptions.”

They should simply feel:

“This version of YouTube feels more personal to me.”

UX Direction That Felt Better

Instead of exposing complicated pricing systems, the experience should probably feel invisible.

For example: rather than asking users to manually optimize subscriptions, YouTube may naturally suggest:

“You already watch these creators regularly. Would you like to make your YouTube more personal?”

That feels softer and simpler.

The system may remain operationally complex internally, while emotionally simple externally.

A Broader Strategic Thought

The more I explored this idea, the more it stopped feeling like a feature.

It started feeling like a restructuring of digital ATTENTION economics.

Current systems optimize:

- scale,
- interruptions,
- and mass retention.

This model may optimize:

- loyalty,
- depth,
- creator relationships,
- and intentional engagement.

That difference fascinated me.

Final Reflection

I do not know whether this model would practically work at YouTube scale.

But what interested me was how one simple user frustration slowly opened questions around:

- creator economy,
- monetization,
- platform incentives,
- behavioral psychology,
- subscription fatigue,
- recommendation systems,
- ATTENTION economics,
- ecosystem balancing,
- and UX simplicity.

This became less of a “startup idea” and more of a product and systems thinking exercise for me.

And honestly, I enjoyed exploring how one small change could affect an entire platform ecosystem.

Original Conversational Exploration

The following excerpts are intentionally retained in their natural conversational form to reflect the raw exploration, questioning style, and thought progression behind the discussion.

PROMPT 1 — Initial Product Thought

"well, i just had a thought."

"i'm quiet active on youtube these days. watching Tedx and cia tactics of Andrew Bustamante..."

"BUYING SUBSCRIPTIONS DEDICATED TO OUR FAVOURITE CHANNELS ONLY"

"i would only pay for the channels i'm interested in and make my youtube personalized."

"this is one way to get more premium customers, might improve the revenue and engagement as well."

"companies functioning on short content algorithms might have a good competition here."

"people do not prefer youtube coz its got ads."

"shorts fulfill the idea of 5-10 sec content and would hit personalized dopamine."

"CTR of videos may increase..."

"it would really help the premium customers get personalized training on youtube rather than them buying their personalized course."

"what could be the consequences, backlashes, and real growth?"

"would it challenge other social media platforms?"

"does it make the customers lazy enough and earn from them?"

"every aspect to be covered."

PROMPT 2 — Pricing Structure & Bundles

"can we make a move like 3 channels for 79 rupees only..."

"it must not be currency biased but value/worth biased."

"then we might move to quantify on the basis of subscribers, likes, comments, ENGAGEMENT RATE..."

"buy 1 channel for -\$ or Rs."

"buy 3 channels for -\$ or Rs."

"buy 7 channels for -\$ or Rs."

"buy youtube premium -\$ or Rs."

"this might not kill the newbies wanting to grow via youtube..."

"we might keep the window open for the user switch from youtube premium/channel premium to normal youtube for everyone."

PROMPT 3 — Counterarguments & Ecosystem Loops

"Problem 1: Big Creators Become Too Expensive..."

"users may feel punished for liking successful creators."

"Problem 2: Creators Will Game Metrics..."

"comments, engagement, likes..."

"ragebait, controversy, emotional manipulation, spam engagement..."

"higher engagement = higher subscription tier."

"Problem 3: Complexity Kills Adoption..."

"Consumers like SIMPLE pricing."

"Netflix succeeds because: easy to understand, predictable."

"This creator costs +₹20 due to engagement score... people mentally quit."

"this is where it regulates..."

"people making content on a massive scale would receive engagement and help them grow."

"when they make a reach to certain level, the growth would be regulated again and this is how it becomes an interlocked cycle."

"If creators manipulate the engagement metrics..."

"that strengthens youtube premium subscriptions or people mostly would hop back to normal youtube."

“now here we might introduce CREDIT POINTS...”

“would keep the hang of the loop again.”

PROMPT 4 — Advertising & Monetization Observation

“ads impressions would not die rather, it might get fragmented...”

“even premium accounts get an ad image...”

“it's just it won't be in the video.”

PROMPT 5 — UX & NAVIGATION Concern

“what i just fear is...”

“now youtube would have more components to add.”

“i only have a NAVIGATIONAL fear.”

“how could it be made simpler?”